

# Professor Interview with John Hendrix (Esther Hong)

## Passage 1

So I guess I'm asking like how do you kind of like conceptualize these like deeper and somewhat complicated themes into an artistic way without the meaning getting lost in all of the illustrative elements? Well, so the trick with telling visual stories like this is to not simplify them, but clarify them.

Right? Mm-hmm. So clarity is actually something that's very difficult to achieve, which involves choosing what elements to talk about and how to show and tell those elements to make the meaning come through

## Passage 2

I'm taking something and translating it into a new visual form and the, the. The magic word for this in comics and, and, and visual theory is multimodal or like, like the multimodality of storytelling where you have like a visual element, right? A text element, maps, comics, like all these things are really interesting into how they [00:14:00] unpack learning for the mind.

## Passage 3

Do you usually start with your idea and immediately just start drawing whatever comes to your mind? Or do you start with like a more systematic, like research and then compile like a vision board with like. Whatever. I don't know, like the elements that, the story Yeah.

Again, it's, you've got it all these, all these things happen at the same time. I don't really go in a linear process. I, I always start with images. Um, I make a board. Sometimes it's a Pinterest board, sometimes it's a physical bulletin board. Um mm-hmm. I, I do research trips like I went. Salem and Danvers, uh, last year.

## Passage 4

So would your best, like what would your best piece of advice be for like, just, I don't know, getting started? Is it just to get started? Well, the, when you're a young artist and you're trying to make stuff, you can't sit down and like say, I'm gonna write a 300 page graphic novel. Right, right. So you need to start with very small things.

You need to take like mm-hmm. An eight page zine. You need to make a very small story and learn how to do that and finish it. That's the most important thing. You can't quit in the middle. You gotta finish it. Right. That's why it needs to be short, and then you need to start over and do another story. Like you, you can't work on the same story for 10 years.

You, you have to try new things. That's the easiest way to learn, is when we engage a new kind of subject matter. Mm-hmm. Yeah. That makes a lot of sense.

**Passage 5**

Usually when students are, are working on a project like this, what they're most interested in, in is the result like, I need to get a object at the end. Right? Right. As opposed to focused on the process, right? Mm-hmm. You can focus on process.

More than result, you will do more learning. Right. And that's the goal. So like if you have three weeks, you know, obviously you can't write and illustrate a picture book in that, right? Mm-hmm. Right. So you gotta think, okay, what is the thing I wanna learn the most? And maybe it is writing a summary, write, doing a cover illustration that engages the title, what the images are, and who the characters are. Because most characters need to be on the front cover. Yeah. And working on like. Manuscript that that over three weeks is something that becomes more possible